

Well Begun HALF DONE

The proactive state Vigilance Department's drive to arrest corrupt government officials loses steam midway and the conviction rate is virtually negligible

| By Amitabh Srivastava |

Ever since the Nitish Kumar Government took over Bihar in November 2005, the state Vigilance Department has sent heads rolling and thrones toppling by its ongoing crackdown on corruption. Nitish's drive has received screaming headlines in Bihar and across India. Since January 2006, almost 400 government officials and their accomplices have been caught red-handed accepting bribe in 353 traps set by the vigilance officials. This is a substantial leap from the past, as between 1995-2005, the bureau had trapped only 47 government officials taking bribes. The current government's zeal for the anti-corruption drive is turning out to be a clear differentiator, separating Nitish from his predecessors.

But well begun is only half done. A reality check reveals that although eradicating corruption is the government's aim, the focus alone has not helped. Go beyond the impressive figures of the trap cases and the success story scripted by the Vigilance Department appears a telling case study of how sometimes even the best laid plans don't yield results. Here are the lesser heard facts—only two of the nearly 400 government officials caught with their hands in the till during last four years have been convicted. The rest, however, have not escaped the legal dragnet yet.

But these figures are not good enough to qualify even for the footnote space in the otherwise less-than-

impressive overall conviction rate of 19.7 per cent clocked by the state in 2008—as maintained by the National Crime Record Bureau's latest 'Crime in India' report. This is not all; since the accused officer cannot be dismissed without conviction, not even 1 per cent of the officials caught in Bihar

have been shown the door. Worse still, almost 75 requests seeking prosecution sanctions against trapped officials are said to be pending at various levels in various departments. This assumes significance since Section 19 of the Prevention of Corruption Act mandates that no cognizance of a

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